

Paradiem
The Morning Brief
SEPTEMBER 21, 2026

Xi Week Setup

Sunday-evening futures point higher into a Trump-Xi state visit anchored on Wednesday-Thursday, with a week of consumer earnings, flash PMIs, and Fed speakers punctuating the docket.

S&P 500 (SPY, FRI CLOSE) \$761.69 · ↓0.12%	NASDAQ (QQQ) / DOW (DIA, FRI) \$721.45 ↑0.63% / \$515.88 ↓0.48%	BITCOIN (LIVE) / IBIT (FRI) ~\$81K per CoinDesk · IBIT \$46.02 ↑6.28%	BRENT (BNO) / WTI (USO, FRI) \$60.57 ↓0.56% / \$153.82 ↓0.96%	FEAR & GREED (CNN STOCK) ~29 Fear per MacroMicro · Drop crypto fallback 70
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SECTION 01

Markets — Sunday-Evening Lift Into Xi Week

FUTURES POINT HIGHER AHEAD OF THE MONDAY CASH SESSION

Per Bloomberg and CNBC coverage of the Sunday-evening tape, US equity futures reportedly pointed higher into Monday’s open, with S&P 500 futures reportedly up approximately 0.5%, Nasdaq-100 futures reportedly up approximately 0.7%, and Dow futures reportedly up approximately 0.44% as of the reported overnight readings — a setup that reportedly follows Friday’s modestly mixed close (SPY ↓0.12% at \$761.69, QQQ ↑0.63% at \$721.45, DIA ↓0.48% at \$515.88 per data drop) and a Dow week that reportedly slid approximately 1.7% per CNBC coverage, extending the recent weekly-decline pattern noted in prior briefs. Per Investing.com and StreetStats technical readings referenced across Sunday coverage, SPY reportedly sits above its 50-day exponential moving average and well above its 200-day simple moving average, framing a still-constructive intermediate technical structure into a week where the Trump-Xi state visit reportedly anchors Wednesday and Thursday. Per data drop, Carson’s active SPY support level at \$645.80 (retracement target set April 13) remains untouched, with Friday’s reported intraday low of \$757.97 well above that level.

S&P 500 (SPY, FRI CLOSE)	\$761.69 · ↓0.12% per data drop
NASDAQ (QQQ) / DOW (DIA, FRI)	\$721.45 ↑0.63% / \$515.88 ↓0.48% per data drop
SUNDAY FUTURES (APPROX)	ES ↑~0.5% / NQ ↑~0.7% / YM ↑~0.44% per Bloomberg, CNBC
FED FUNDS TARGET RANGE	3.75%–4.00% · First hike since 2023 per Fed statement
USO / BNO (FRI CLOSE)	\$153.82 ↓0.96% / \$60.57 ↓0.56% per data drop
IBIT / ETHA (FRI CLOSE)	\$46.02 ↑6.28% / \$19.92 ↑7.85% per data drop
CARSON'S ACTIVE SPY SUPPORT	\$645.80 retracement target · Untouched (Fri low \$757.97)

FED PATH — WARSH FRAMING KEEPS A HAWKISH SKEW PRICED

Per CNBC and Kiplinger coverage of the September 16 FOMC decision carried into the weekend, the Federal Open Market Committee reportedly voted 12–0 to raise the federal funds target range by 25 basis points to 3.75%–4.00% — reportedly the first rate increase since July 2023 — and updated projections reportedly showed 16 of the 18 participants expecting another rate increase before year-end, with four reportedly seeing two additional hikes as possible. Per CNBC coverage of the post-meeting communications, Fed Chair Kevin Warsh reportedly laid out a relatively hawkish framing, reportedly signaling that underlying inflation trends have not meaningfully improved and reportedly characterizing the hike as removing a dose of accommodation rather than reflecting particularly restrictive policy. Per iShares and StreetStats coverage of fed funds futures, market pricing reportedly

implies a policy rate near approximately 4.2% by December and reportedly near 4.7% by September 2027, framing a path that keeps the FCI Dividend sleeve reading through the intersection of persistent inflation, the reported energy-cost passthrough, and the housing-cycle signal into the Wednesday PMIs and the Friday Durable Goods print.

DIGITAL ASSETS EXTENDING ON THE TOKENIZED-STOCK REGULATORY CLEARANCE

Per CoinDesk and Benzinga coverage of the September 20–21 weekend tape, Bitcoin reportedly traded above approximately \$81,000 with a reported brief touch near \$82,000 late Saturday before easing, extending Friday's reported FCI digital-asset move (IBIT ↑6.28% at \$46.02, ETHA ↑7.85% at \$19.92, MARA ↑13.75% at \$13.24, HOOD ↑9.12% at \$119.82, HUT ↑8.52% at \$98.74 per data drop). Per Yahoo Finance and Time News coverage carried into the weekend, the reported rally has drawn its

main catalyst from the SEC's reported September 17 conditional-relief pathway for qualifying tokenized US stocks on eligible venues while the agency reportedly considers longer-term rules, and per Yahoo Finance coverage of ETF flow data, weekly US spot Bitcoin ETF net inflows reportedly totaled approximately \$6.2 million rescued by a reported \$433 million Friday surge (FBTC reportedly \$310.7M, IBIT reportedly \$108.4M), while Ethereum ETFs reportedly took in approximately \$144 million led by ETHA reportedly \$114M. For FCI positioning, the composition — a reported SEC executive-agency clearance rather than a legislative CLARITY Act path, a reported Friday ETF-flow surge, and a weekend extension in the spot tape — keeps IBIT, ETHA, HOOD, MARA, and HUT reading through the intersection of the reported regulatory catalyst, the Fed rate path, and the reported AI-infrastructure buildout into the Trump-Xi week.

A Sunday-evening futures lift into a week anchored by the Trump-Xi Wednesday arrival and Thursday White House welcome, with the SEP median reportedly framing one more hike this year and 16 of 18 participants reportedly aligned with that path, tends to reward reading each catalyst on its own terms rather than compositing a single directional view. Research reveals opportunities.

Geopolitics — Xi Arrival, UNGA Week, and the Fire Pause

XI WEDNESDAY ARRIVAL AT ANDREWS, THURSDAY WHITE HOUSE WELCOME

Per Bloomberg and Tribune coverage of the Chinese Foreign Ministry's September 21 confirmation, General Secretary Xi Jinping reportedly pays a state visit to the United States from September 23 through September 25, with Xi and Peng Liyuan reportedly arriving at Joint Base Andrews on Wednesday September 23 and President Trump reportedly greeting Xi at the airfield — per UNN and Bloomberg coverage of the White House-released program, an unusual military-base reception given that visiting heads of state are typically received at the White House. Per Bloomberg coverage of the itinerary, Thursday September 24 reportedly brings the White House welcome, a Rose Garden military review, bilateral meetings, and the state dinner in the East Room, with prior-brief Bloomberg and ABC News coverage reportedly framing the state dinner as including OpenAI CEO Sam Altman, Nvidia CEO Jensen Huang, Qualcomm CEO Cristiano Amon, and Apple Executive Chairman Tim Cook. Per Bloomberg coverage, this reportedly marks Xi's first White House visit in approximately eleven years, and per Chinese Foreign Ministry coverage, Vice Premier He Lifeng reportedly leads a preparatory delegation to the United States from September 19 through September 23 for economic and trade consultations. For FCI positioning, the composition — a Wednesday airport reception, a Thursday White House welcome and AI-CEO state dinner, and the reported November 10 semiconductor export-control moratorium deadline sitting behind the meeting — keeps NVDA, QCOM, TSM, MRVL, KEYS, TEL, and NXPI reading through the intersection of the Fed rate path, the AI-safety debate, and the Pacific-technology diplomacy channel into the Wednesday-Thursday event.

IRAN FIRE PAUSE INTO UNGA; TRUMP-PEZESHKIAN DOOR REPORTEDLY OPEN

Per Global Security Iran War Day-203 coverage of the September 18 update carried into the weekend, the reported fire pause reportedly held for its ninth day through Thursday with no Iranian ballistic-missile or drone attack on any host state reported through that date, reportedly surviving the publication of UN and Amnesty findings of war crimes and crimes against humanity and the opening of General Assembly week. Per International News and Views coverage of the September 21 UNGA setup, President Trump reportedly left the door open to a possible meeting with Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian at the UN General Assembly while Tehran reportedly warned of sustained retaliation against any fresh American attack, and per the same coverage, the United States reportedly approved access for a core Iranian delegation including Pezeshkian and Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi while reportedly restricting the delegation's movement to a six-block perimeter around UN headquarters. Per Eastern Herald coverage of the September 20 backchannel readout, Iran reportedly transmitted seven conditions for formalizing the ceasefire to the United States through Qatari intermediaries, and per the same coverage, the Trump administration reportedly

continues to draft a “day-after” framework for Iran involving regional containment and expanded Israeli-Arab normalization. Per Eastern Herald coverage carried across the weekend, UN fact-finders reportedly ruled US strikes on the Minab school killed 120 Iranian schoolchildren as war crimes, adding to the UNGA-week diplomatic overlay. For FCI positioning, the composition — a reported fire pause approaching its second week, seven reported Iranian preconditions ahead of Pezeshkian's reported UNGA address, a reported Trump-Pezeshkian meeting possibility, and a widening UN war-crimes finding — keeps CVX, OKE, CNX, LMT, and GD reading through the intersection of the still-live diplomatic map, the reported UN accountability track, and Friday's physical-crude softness (USO ↓0.96%, BNO ↓0.56% per data drop) into Monday.

HOUTH RIYADH STRIKE — KINETIC PERIMETER PERSISTS BENEATH THE PAUSE

Per The Week, Eastern Herald, and Travel Tourister coverage of the September 18–19 overnight attack, Yemen's Houthis reportedly struck Riyadh for the first time in this conflict cycle, reportedly setting an Aramco fuel depot ablaze near King Khalid International Airport and reportedly triggering major flight disruptions at the

airport. Per the same coverage, the Houthis reportedly also claimed a strike on an Aramco facility in Yanbu, and Saudi authorities reportedly confirmed the attack while reportedly reporting no casualties. Per Reuters coverage carried in the data drop headlines, an all-clear was reportedly issued after flames and black smoke were reportedly seen near the airport, and the Houthis reportedly framed the strikes as retaliation for reported Saudi action on Sanaa. For FCI positioning, the composition — a reported first-of-cycle Riyadh airport

strike on a fuel depot with reported Yanbu escalation, a still-live Houthi kinetic perimeter reportedly persisting beneath the Iran ballistic-missile fire pause, and USO $\downarrow 0.96\%$ and BNO $\downarrow 0.56\%$ per data drop reportedly suggesting the physical-crude market reads the incident as contained rather than transformational — keeps CVX, OKE, CNX, LMT, and GD reading through the intersection of a fragmenting kinetic map, the reported UN diplomatic layer, and the Fed rate path into the Wednesday-Thursday state visit.

On Our Radar

1. Week Ahead — Xi Wednesday-Thursday, KB Home Tuesday, Costco Thursday, Flash PMIs Wednesday, Durable Goods

Friday; August PCE Publishes September 30 Per BEA. Per Bloomberg and Tribune coverage of the Chinese Foreign Ministry's September 21 confirmation, Xi Jinping reportedly arrives at Joint Base Andrews Wednesday September 23 with Trump greeting at the airfield, and Thursday September 24 reportedly brings the White House welcome, Rose Garden military review, bilateral meetings, and state dinner in the East Room. Per StockTitan, MarketBeat, and Alphastreet coverage of the week-ahead earnings calendar, KB Home (KBH) and AutoZone (AZO) reportedly report Tuesday September 22, Cintas (CTAS), Paychex (PAYX), and General Mills (GIS) reportedly report Wednesday September 23, and Darden Restaurants (DRI) and Costco (COST) reportedly report Thursday September 24. Per Kiplinger and Investrade coverage of the economic calendar, the Chicago Fed National Activity Index reportedly publishes Tuesday September 22, S&P Global flash September Manufacturing and Services PMIs and the Richmond Fed Manufacturing Index reportedly publish Wednesday September 23, and initial jobless claims, August Durable Goods Orders, the final Q2 GDP release, existing home sales, and wholesale inventories reportedly publish Friday September 25. Per the same coverage, Fed speakers reportedly include Bostic and Bowman on Wednesday. Per the Bureau of Economic Analysis official release schedule, the August Personal Income and Outlays release containing the August PCE Price Index reportedly publishes Wednesday September 30 at 8:30 AM EDT — the week after the state visit rather than this week. For FCI positioning, the composition — a Wednesday-Thursday summit anchoring the AI-CEO Pacific-technology diplomacy channel, a KB Home housing-cycle read Tuesday, a Costco Thursday consumer read coinciding with the White House welcome, and a General Mills food-inflation read into the FCI Dividend sleeve — keeps the investment committee reading through a week where the consumer, housing, PMI, and summit signals reportedly dominate ahead of the following week's first post-hike PCE print.

2. CleanSpark-Meta Data-Center Junk Bond — Reported 4× Oversubscribed at 8.25% Yield. Per Bloomberg, Yahoo Finance, and Crypto Briefing coverage of the reported September 17–18 debut issuance, CleanSpark Inc.'s inaugural junk-bond offering for a Meta Platforms-tied data-center facility reportedly drew orders of approximately \$10 billion against a reported deal size near \$2.28 billion — approximately four times oversubscribed — with the five-year notes reportedly launched at a reported price of 98.5 cents on the dollar to yield approximately 8.25% per Bloomberg coverage. Per Energy Now and Bloomberg coverage of the broader capex cycle, AI-related companies and projects reportedly tapped debt markets for at least \$200 billion in 2025, with reported issuance projections in the hundreds of billions of dollars for 2026 as the reported AI data-center buildout reportedly consumes debt markets. For FCI positioning, the composition — a reported CleanSpark-Meta 4× oversubscription pricing at 8.25% amid Fed funds at 3.75%–4.00%, the reported AI-infrastructure credit absorption signal, and the reported physical-buildout capex cycle referenced through the FCI Growth-Hybrid semiconductor and power-generation sleeves — keeps NVDA, AMD, TSM, MRVL, LRCX, CEG, VST, EIX, and OKE reading through the intersection of AI-infrastructure demand, the reported credit-market signal, and the Fed rate path into the Trump-Xi week.

3. QCOM Into Xi Week — Reported MediaTek 2-Nanometer Flagship Ahead of the Amon State-Dinner Attendance

Thursday. Per data drop, Qualcomm reportedly closed Friday ↓5.82% at \$177.72 with an intraday range from \$175.97 to \$192.12 — a \$16.15 range framing an unusually volatile session — and per TipRanks, The Street, and Seeking Alpha coverage of the reported September 15 launch, MediaTek reportedly unveiled the Dimensity 9600 Pro built on a TSMC 2-nanometer process node, reportedly moving MediaTek ahead of Qualcomm in the reported race to commercialize 2nm silicon for handsets. Per the same coverage, MediaTek reportedly held approximately 32% of the global smartphone-chipset market against Qualcomm's reported approximately 23% in Q1 2026, with MediaTek's reported market capitalization near approximately \$223 billion versus Qualcomm reportedly trailing by approximately \$22 billion. Per data drop, the sleeve-internal picture Friday was mixed with AMD ↑2.70% at \$559.82, CRDO ↑4.54% at \$175.89, LRCX ↑6.98% at \$288.11, MRVL ↑1.45% at \$244.25, TSM ↑1.02% at \$434.67, and NVDA ↑1.34% at \$222.27. For FCI positioning, the composition — a QCOM Friday reversal into the Trump-Xi week where Cristiano Amon reportedly attends the state dinner, a MediaTek 2-nanometer competitive-pressure signal, and a sleeve-internal semiconductor-equipment leadership tape via LRCX and CRDO — keeps the FCI Growth-Hybrid physical-AI-infrastructure sleeve reading through the intersection of the reported November 10 export-control moratorium expiration, the Fed rate path, and the intra-sleeve rotation into the Monday cash session.

4. Consumer & Housing Docket — KB Home Tuesday After Close, Costco & Darden Thursday Alongside the White House

Welcome. Per Nasdaq press release and Alphastreet coverage, KB Home reportedly releases Q3 (fiscal quarter ended August 31) earnings after the market close Tuesday September 22 with the earnings call at 5 PM ET, and per Yahoo Finance and TipRanks coverage of the consensus setup, KB Home reportedly guides deliveries in a range of 2,600–2,800 homes and housing revenues in a range of approximately \$1.20 billion to \$1.35 billion with housing gross margin reportedly guided to a range of 16.0%–16.6%, against reported consensus for approximately \$0.90 EPS and approximately \$1.30 billion in revenue. Per TipRanks and MarketBeat coverage, Costco (COST) reportedly releases Q4 fiscal 2026 earnings after market close Thursday September 24 with reported consensus at approximately \$6.55 adjusted EPS and approximately \$94.85 billion in revenue — the same day as the reported White House welcome and state dinner. Per data drop, TOL reportedly closed Friday ↓0.94% at \$133.06 with an intraday range of \$132.11 to \$134.50, and the broader FCI consumer-cyclical layer moved with GPC ↓2.14% at \$128.08, FAST ↓0.35% at \$49.01, and SYF ↑0.85% at \$75.04. For FCI positioning, the composition — a KB Home housing-cycle print Tuesday against a reported approximately 44% year-over-year EPS decline consensus setup, a Costco Thursday report coinciding with the reported White House welcome and state dinner, and a TOL Friday close reading through the housing-cycle framing — keeps TOL, GPC, FAST, and SYF reading through the Fed rate path, the consumer signal, and the Trump-Xi diplomatic channel simultaneously.

5. Fed Speaker Wall — Reported Ten Central-Bank Appearances Across the Week, Bostic and Bowman Wednesday. Per Kiplinger and FXStreet coverage of the week-ahead Fed calendar, central-bank speakers reportedly make approximately ten appearances across the week with reported governors Bostic and Bowman reportedly scheduled for Wednesday September 23 alongside the reported flash PMIs and Xi's arrival, framing the week's reported communication path from Chair Warsh's reported post-hike hawkish setup. Per iShares 2026 Fed outlook coverage and Yahoo Finance coverage of the reported post-SEP fed funds futures curve, market pricing reportedly implies a policy rate near approximately 4.2% by December and near approximately 4.7% by September 2027, framing a wall of Fed communication that reportedly matters for the FCI Dividend sleeve's duration and payout sensitivity. Per data drop, TLT reportedly closed Friday $\downarrow 0.65\%$ at \$81.25 while UVXY (VIX proxy) reportedly closed $\uparrow 0.52\%$ at \$17.53, framing a Friday tape where long-duration Treasuries reportedly lagged. For FCI positioning, the composition — a reported ten-speaker Fed communication wall, a Wednesday flash-PMI print, and a Friday Durable Goods release framing the August investment-cycle read — keeps ADI, ADP, SSNC, SPGI, GD, LMT, CAT, and FAST reading through the intersection of the rate path, the reported industrial-capex signal, and the reported inflation persistence into the Trump-Xi week.

6. Digital-Asset Miners & Brokers — MARA, HUT, HOOD Momentum Alongside a Reported \$81K Bitcoin Weekend. Per CoinDesk, Benzinga, and Time News coverage of the September 20–21 weekend tape, Bitcoin reportedly traded above approximately \$81,000 with a reported brief touch near \$82,000 late Saturday before easing back near the reported \$81,000 area. Per data drop, Friday's FCI digital-asset layer moved with MARA $\uparrow 13.75\%$ at \$13.24, HOOD $\uparrow 9.12\%$ at \$119.82, HUT $\uparrow 8.52\%$ at \$98.74, IBIT $\uparrow 6.28\%$ at \$46.02, and ETHA $\uparrow 7.85\%$ at \$19.92, and per Yahoo Finance coverage of ETF flow data, weekly US spot Bitcoin ETF net inflows reportedly totaled approximately \$6.2 million rescued by a reported \$433 million Friday surge with FBTC reportedly \$310.7M and IBIT reportedly \$108.4M, while Ethereum ETFs reportedly took in approximately \$144 million led by ETHA reportedly \$114M. For FCI positioning, the composition — a reported weekend Bitcoin extension above approximately \$81,000, a reported ETF-flow surge concentrated in Friday's tape, and a HOOD reportedly $\uparrow 9.12\%$ into a week where the SEC tokenized-stock exemption remains the marginal catalyst — keeps IBIT, ETHA, HOOD, MARA, and HUT reading through the intersection of the reported regulatory clearance, the Fed rate path, and the reported AI-infrastructure buildout into the Monday cash session.

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